Dave and I just hit it off and we've been close ever since: I was best man at his wedding in the summer of 2003. He stayed on as an apprentice until he was eighteen, by which time I was playing regularly in the first team. Dave turned professional with Manchester City and he still plays non-League with Altrincham. Nowadays, for him, soccer's about staying fit and keeping his eye in: he's a full-time director of a sports management company.

During those first years at United, Eric used to make sure we went to every first-team game at Old Trafford. Not just to watch the game, but to watch individual players. I'd think back to Dad taking me to Cup Finals when I was a boy.

'Never mind the game, David. Just watch Bryan Robson. Watch what he does.'

Now Eric was telling us the same thing: 'Watch the man playing in your position. One day, you're going to take his place.'

To hear something like that gave us so much confidence; not that we realized at the time how soon the manager was going to make us all part of his first-team plans.

Going to those games at Old Trafford was a chance, as well, for Eric to insist on the importance of having standards. He always made sure that we turned up in a blazer, with a collar and tie. It reminded me of Stuart Underwood wanting the Ridgeway players to be well turned out when we arrived for big games. I still think those things make a difference. Some teams might be seen arriving at a ground or walking through an airport in their tracksuits. The fact that a Manchester United team will always be wearing club blazers is part of having a professional attitude. That smartness said something about our respect for ourselves and for the club.

Our training sessions weren't all about technique and tactics and learning new tricks. If Eric spotted a weakness in your game, you could be sure he'd do his best to confront it. I don't know if 'Headers' was designed just to make me suffer, but some mornings it felt like it. As a forward player, you need to be strong enough to hold your own physically against bigger and tougher defenders. Heading and tackling weren't exactly my strong points, especially as I was smaller than most of the other lads. 'Headers' was Eric's way of toughening up young players like me. There were two teams: midfielders and forwards lined up against defenders. The ball was chipped up and you could only score with your head. That would have been fine, except it was an invitation to the likes of Gary Neville and Chris Casper to come crashing into